Welcome to The Uptone Girls' Audition Pack!

Hi! Thank you so much for considering joining ***The Uptone Girls***; we're so excited to hear from you all and to see all the talent that you have to offer.

We are an all-female identifying competitive a cappella group at the University of Birmingham and as a result we are only able to accept students enrolled at our university. The Uptone Girls are a close-knit, musical community where passion, creativity and friendship thrive.

This academic year will be the sixteenth generation of The Uptone Girls and we are holding both online and in person auditions to recruit our next set of singers and vocal percussionists! As you will likely be aware, our online auditions are now open until the **26th September at 12pm (noon).** Dates for in person auditions will be announced in due time, but will most likely be on or around the weekend of the week beginning the **21st of September** (more details late in this document).

This document should give you a greater idea of who we are and what we accomplish as a group, but if you have any further questions please do not hesitate to reach out via our Instagram or TikTok DMs and we will be more than happy to answer them!

Auditions:

As we've already said, thank you so much for considering joining us and we're so excited to hear from all of you as we search for Generation 16 of The Uptone Girls!

As a group we have been referred to as "the real life Barden Bellas", and if you've seen the film *Pitch Perfect* then you might therefore have a greater understanding of what we do. The Uptone Girls are an all female a cappella group from the University of Birmingham, meaning that we sing without a backing track and create melodies, harmonies and rhythms using just our voices. Additionally, we are a competitive group, which means that every year we enter for a chance to participate in the International Championship of Collegiate A Capella or the ICCAs (also featured in *Pitch Perfect*). This year we made it through to the quarter finals where we competed in our home city of Birmingham, eventually coming fourth overall in our heat. For more information see the **'Competitions and Performances'** section of this document.

As we are competitors, this means that we can only have a set number of members in the group, and the competition **maximum** is **18 members**.

The Uptone Girls offer both online and in person auditions for the group. All auditionees must be enrolled at the University of Birmingham for the 2026/27 academic year and should be female identifying. In terms of previous experience, we have **no** expectation to have any prior musical training or to be able to read music to join - we want to be inclusive of all those who are thinking of joining, so please do not worry if you are a novice and/or have no prior experience in an a cappella group.

Our online auditions are currently open and are submissible via our email address: uptonegirlsacapella@gmail.com We will continue to accept auditions until **noon (12pm) on the 26th of September 2026**. This is to ensure that we have time enough to do our due diligence in viewing all of your applications in time to let you know about any potential call backs.

If you wish to audition in person, our provisional dates will be on **Friday 25th of September and Saturday 26th of September**. Unfortunately, we don't have any further details to share as of yet, but as soon as we do they will be available on our Instagram page and this document will be updated. If you wish to ask us any questions before you audition, our Publicity and Press Officer will be on hand to answer Instagram and TikTok DMs, so please send any questions our way. We kindly ask that you do not direct any questions to the email address above so that our inbox is not overwhelmed alongside online auditionees and that we can answer your questions as soon as possible.

Both methods of auditioning will entail the same steps so that the process is fair and even for everyone. Please be prepared to do the following:

1. Please sing a song of your choice a cappella (i.e. without any background music).
2. Then, we ask that you harmonise for approximately one minute with another song of your choosing.
3. We will also require:
    a. Your full name
    b. Year of study
    c. Course name
    d. Any musical experience that you have.

Once all in person auditions are completed, you will receive an email from us stating whether or not you have made it through to callbacks. As we have said, competition rules means that we can only accept a certain number of people so please do not take it personally if you did not make it through, and we encourage you to audition again next year if you are willing and able.

Regardless of if you are auditioning in person or online, you must be available on the **27th of September 2026** for an **in person callback** (once again, this date is provisional, and we will release more details when we can). . It will last for approximately two hours and we will send out any material for you to familiarise yourself with in advance; you do not need to know any of it inside out just ensure that you know the content well enough.

During the callbacks we will ask you to perform in smaller groups, perform a short section of choreography and we will go through some of the basics of beatboxing and vocal percussion. We may also undergo range testing to determine which voice part (soprano, mezzo or alto) you are best suited to.

It's a very relaxed experience and allows both us and you to get a greater impression of what is to come and how you would act in a group setting.

After this callback, you will receive another email which tells you if you have been accepted into the group.This email will contain further details about our first meeting/rehearsal and from there you will officially become a part of The Uptone Girls! Stating this again, competition rules means that we can only accept a certain number of people so please do not take it personally if you did not make it through, and we encourage you to audition again next year if you are willing and able.

Expectations:

As we are a competitive group, we do have high standards for our members so that we can all perform to the best of our ability. These are some of the expectations that we have for each other, but remember we can be flexible and we understand that sometimes things can go wrong.

Rehearsals and attendance:
We require that you attend all rehearsals unless you are unwell, or have given us sufficient notice as to why you cannot attend. Our rehearsals are twice weekly lasting two hours each; we schedule these around everyone's timetables and other commitments so please do not worry about skipping lectures to attend rehearsal. All rehearsals will take place in the Guild of Students or at a member's house if there are no rooms available, but this will be communicated the day before rehearsal. If you fail to attend a sufficient number of rehearsals, we will have to discuss whether or not you can perform with the group.

We also have an expectation that all members can commit to a week of intense rehearsal hours across one week in January (dubbed **Bootcamp** - see the next section titled **'Schedule'** for more information) and more intense rehearsal hours on our journey to the ICCA quarter-finals (and hopefully further)! This allows us to meet up with the purpose of dedicating time to our ICCAs' set and so that all members of the group know what they need to do during the set/practice at home.

Attending any rehearsal is imperative as everyone's part in each piece will link together and your absence could mean that someone else struggles to piece together their own addition to the arrangement. Similarly, missing a rehearsal means that you yourself won't be able to hear how your part in the arrangement matches up to anyone else's.

Once parts are distributed, you will be expected to learn them in your own time where you can so that we can all be in the best place possible when we all come together to rehearse. However, if you're struggling, please do not worry as we all need help sometimes and we are happy to help if you are really stuck and have tried your best independently.

Competing:
By auditioning for the group you are expected to be willing to perform and take part in competitions. This not only involves singing but choreography too and an agreement to be available on competition days when we disclose them. If you're not a dancer (as most of us aren't), please do not worry - the choreography is relatively easy and we all help each other out so that we can perform to the best of our ability (which is maybe why we got awarded **Outstanding Choreography for our 2026 ICCAs set**)!

Social media:
Social media is an important part of the Uptones, and we work very hard to create a consistent online presence and brand for the group. Ideally, you will be happy to be on social media and to participate in our content. If not, we hope that you understand the importance of dedicating a portion of time to creating content for our pages.

Behaviour:
The Uptone Girls are a sisterhood where we champion creativity, friendship and supportiveness. We do **not** under any circumstance tolerate unfriendly behaviour of any sort. This includes singling people out, homophobia, racism or anti-social behaviour of any kind. We are a supportive group of women who work together and encourage each other to be the best we can be, and the culture that we set is incredibly valuable to us.

We hope that you understand that our expectations are in place so that we can best support you and the rest of the group so that we can thrive as a team. There are circumstances in which we can be lenient, but behaviour in particular is of the utmost importance to us and is non-negotiable if you are to join us. Thank you for your understanding.

Schedule:
We know it's a cliche, but the year really does go very quickly! This means that we have more to do in a limited amount of time (but we'll hopefully have a lot of fun along the way).

Semester one:
As already said auditions and callbacks will be concluded around the 27th of September. This means that we will have our 16th Generation of Uptone Girls by the beginning of October (just before lectures begin). We will also have our first rehearsal around this time where we will be able to meet everyone and come together as a group to create some incredible music.

Also in semester one, we will take our group headshots. This will only happen during rehearsal time so please don't worry about having to dedicate any extra time/or miss any lectures in order to participate in these. These will take place either just before reading week or just after depending on what our rehearsal schedule looks like during this period of semester one.

The first round of the ICCAs happens online and submissions are due relatively early into the autumn term, so during one rehearsal we will be recording our submission to be sent off with the hopes of progression to the quarter finals. This is very low pressure and we can take as many takes as needed to record our submission, so don't let this dissuade you from auditioning!

Towards the end of this first term, we will host a Christmas gig. This is usually in the form of a fundraiser in which we can raise money for the group. This will usually be in the last week of the semester (around the 7th of December). Not only will we perform a range of Christmas songs to set the festive mood, but we will also perform other arrangements that we have learnt over the course of the semester.

Semester two:
Over the Christmas holidays, we will send out parts for our ICCAs set which we expect you to have a listen to over the break so that we can get started with putting together the arrangements as soon as the semester starts.

As aforementioned, we will host a bootcamp during the first week or so of January, and after this (and until ICCAs) rehearsals may become more frequent in order to sufficiently prepare us for our competition. As we do with the ordinary rehearsal scheduling we will organise this to the best of our ability around everyone's timetables and we will never encourage you to miss a lecture for our sake!

ICCAs themselves will take place around the end of January to the middle of February, but we won't know the official date until we qualify and know which heat we are competing in.

The UK heats for 2026 took place on the following dates, so we imagine next year will be similar times: 31st January, 8th February, 15th February (two heats took place on this day) and the 22nd of February. Our quarter final this year was in Birmingham itself, but be aware that we may have to travel to another part of the country in order to compete. Should we progress any further in the competition, we will take it step by step and release all details to our members when we know what they are.

Once we have completed our ICCAs run, our schedule significantly calms down. In March we may have an opportunity to perform in and attend The Guild Awards hosted at the university. This involves a short performance and a dinner if you are willing to pay for your ticket and this is approximately £25.

Semester three:
The last semester of the academic year is the most relaxed for us, but we hope that there will be more performance opportunities for us this year, such as the Midlands Showcase and potentially Croacappella which is an a cappella summer camp held in Croatia but we will assess who wants to participate in this closer to the time as there is a fee to pay.

There may also be opportunities within the university to perform, such as a part of UOB Xtra. This is the university's summer program which not only has performances and fun activities but also helps to boost your CV.

These are just some of the events that we will engage in throughout the year, and I'm sure our Social Secretary will plan many socials for us all to enjoy too!

Competitions and Performances:

As previously mentioned, our main competition is the International Championship of Collegiate A Cappella which has its first in person heats in January/February. Initial heats happen at the end of October or beginning of November, but we will have confirmed dates closer to the time. As mentioned in the previous section, the online heat will happen within an existing rehearsal slot, so you will not have to dedicate any additional time to this part of the process.

Should we progress to the quarter finals, we will attend one day of competition in a UK venue, which we will not know the location of until we qualify. Our 2026 heat was luckily in Birmingham itself, meaning that we did not have to travel far at all, but in previous years we have travelled to Nottingham, London and Exeter so please be prepared to travel in order to be able to compete.

ICCAs are such a great opportunity for us to perform on a bigger stage and in front of a larger number of people, but also to meet other incredible a cappella groups from across the UK. This year we competed against Northern Lights from Durham University who went on from there to come second in the whole competition after competing in the finals in New York! The quality of the competition is incredibly high and we are privileged to be included with such a talented group of musicians.

Other performances throughout the year include our Christmas gig. This is a brilliant first performance for us as it allows us to showcase what we've learnt since forming the next generation of Uptones! Even though it's called a Christmas fundraiser, we do not just perform Christmas songs. Last year we performed *Hey Ya* by Outkast, a *Hamilton* and *Alicia Keys* mashup and more! This is a more intimate opportunity for us to showcase our talent and what we have been working on over the course of our first semester together. This will usually take place in the last week of semester one and will usually take place in the form of a fundraiser. This allows us to either raise money for a charity of our choosing (for example in the past we have raised money for Action Against Homelessness) or to raise money for the group itself on our road to competing in the ICCAs as there is an entry fee.

This year we had the opportunity to perform as a part of the university's summer experience program, UOB Xtra, which meant that we performed on The Green Heart in front of UOB's stunning library. This meant we performed a short 15 minute set showcasing some more new arrangements, such as *Crabbuckit* and *Ebb Tide* which we learnt during the summer term.

As previously stated, there may be other opportunities to perform this year and as we become aware of them, we will communicate them to our members with sufficient time for us to prepare for them to the best of our ability.